

# An Enchanted Memory

The writer's personal search leads her to many little known minority communities

| By Gillian Wright |



**THE GIRL FROM FOREIGN: A SEARCH FOR SHIPWRECKED ANCESTORS, FORGOTTEN HISTORIES AND A SENSE OF HOME**  
by SADIA SHEPARD  
Penguin  
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This is yet another NRI nostalgia trip, with an American girl returning to discover her roots. But just as you begin to wonder whether you can bear another writer describing her perfect Indian grandmother and how she made chapatis, the book begins to hook you. For a start, Sadia Shepard is a very clever woman. She is a filmmaker who came back to India on a Fulbright scholarship and she clearly understands communication. You cannot fault her writing, which is lucid, honest and bare of unnecessary adjectives. She also has an attractive humility. And on top of this, as all families have secrets, at least as strange as fiction, she also has a story to tell.

Some years ago, I was in Jerusalem for the opening of the Indian gallery in the impressive Israel Museum. An entire synagogue had been imported from Cochin and reconstructed as an exhibit. The gallery told the stories of the various Indian Jewish communities, and especially the Bene Israel or the Sanichar Telis, Jews of Maharashtra, who for centuries had extracted oil and rested on the Sabbath. Most of them had migrated to Israel, and a good number were at the opening, singing along to Raj Kapoor hits and recalling the land of their birth, India. Though most of them are today in Israel, Shepard comes to India to study them. This is because of her own relationship to them. Shepard's father is Christian, her mother Muslim, and her grandmother was a Muslim too. But she discovered by chance that her grandmother's original name was Rachel Jacobs and she was a Bene Israel Jew. She had fallen

in love with a Muslim businessman, already married twice over. They wed and she lived in Mumbai in her own independent bungalow by the sea until the Partition, when the family migrated to Karachi. After her husband's death, her grandmother came to live with her daughter in the US and acted as an extra parent to Shepard as she grew up. So this is a book about a girl with connections to three religions and three countries—the US, Pakistan and India. Shepard tells the story of her grandmother in the US and revisits Pakistan where her relatives have gutted her grandmother's flat, stripping it even of electrical fittings in their greed. But her grandmother loved her life in Mumbai the most, and so India is the most important country in this book.

In the process of her personal search, and her scholarship aim of studying Indian Jews, Shepard discovers little known communities who have lived and still live as tiny minorities surrounded by their Muslim and Hindu neighbours. The virus of Muslim-Jewish distrust, which has flourished since the creation of Israel, is alien to them. Shepard describes the people

she meets as rounded individuals and discovers what she believes is the only family left that still continues the community's traditional occupation of oil pressing. The head of the family tells her that their ancestors were shipwrecked off the Indian coast many centuries ago. "We have no problem in India," he repeatedly tells her, representing the best of Indian tradition, a true pluralism, which respects each individual's search for Truth. Shepard's own optimism and empathy are reflected in those she meets, like this Bene Israel family, making this book a truly enchanting read. ■



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